

IN BRIEF

LOSING THE CHAINS

Communist revolutions during the 20th century saw women's fight for equality as integral to the wider class struggle, and their ideas greatly influenced gender equality.

1800-1900

- **1848** Marx and Engels publish the *Communist Manifesto*, explaining the class system.
- **1899** Nadezhda Krupskaya applies Marxist theory to Russian women in *The Woman Worker*.
- **1907** At the First International Conference of Socialist Women in Stuttgart, Germany, Alexandra Kollontai declares: "The struggle to achieve political equality for proletarian women is part ... of the overall class struggle ..."
- **1917** Socialist women's journal *Rabotnitsa* calls for an anti-war demonstration. Women start the "bread and peace" strike in Petrograd in March. In July, Russian women win the right to vote and hold public office.
- **1918** On August 30, Fanny Kaplan shoots Lenin three times as he is leaving a Moscow factory. She calls him "a traitor to the revolution." Although injured badly, Lenin survives.
- **1919** Zhenotdel, the women's section of the Russian Communist Party, is established.
- **1920s** Alexandra Kollontai tries to bring more gender diversity into the Communist Party but meets resentment.
- **1930** Zhenotdel is shut down and women's issues declared "solved" due to nationalization and the abolition of private property.
- **1934** Zhang Qinqiu heads the Women's Independent Regiment of the Fourth Front Army in China, commanding 2,000 female soldiers.
- **1949** The Communists seize power in China.
- **1950** The New Marriage Law of the People's Republic of China sets out civil rights for women.
- **1959** Women form the front line of struggle during the Cuban Revolution, bringing a communist regime to power.
- **1961** Cuban women and girls play a leading role in the literacy brigades that teach people to read and write, making Cuba one of the most literate countries in the Western hemisphere.

► 1930 PROPAGANDA POSTER FOR INTERNATIONAL WOMEN WORKER'S DAY

